

EKPO

A Feature Screenplay

Working Draft
July 25, 2026

FADE IN:

INT. SOLOMON'S HOUSE - PRE-DAWN

A kettle begins to whistle. MALIK OKU, 36, appears from the pantry in funeral trousers and a white undershirt. He crosses the kitchen before the whistle reaches its full voice. Switches off the burner.

Checks the other three. All cold. The house around him is ready for a man who will not come downstairs. At the entrance: A polished pair of black shoes. A carved walking stick.

Prayer beads looped carefully over the handle. In the living room: ACHEBE beside SOYINKA. An EFIK BIBLE with a repaired spine. Canadian immigration manuals, decades out of date.

A brass leopard on a tray darkened by fingerprints. Family photographs arranged with almost obsessive care. One frame hangs crooked. The only one. In the kitchen: Gari. Crayfish. Maggi. Peak Milk. Ovaltine.

Three mustard jars in the refrigerator door. One thriving plant on the sill. Two dead ones beside it. Malik pours hot water into a mug. Does not drink. He wipes an already-clean section of counter. Stops.

Looks toward the staircase. Nothing there but the pale square of the landing. The front door opens. ADE OKU, 32, enters carrying his dress shoes. His tie hangs around his neck like a surrender flag.

He watches Malik wipe the same place again.

ADE

You know they sell those
pre-cleaned.

MALIK

You said six-thirty.

ADE

I meant emotionally.

Malik checks his watch. 6:41. Then the wall clock. 6:40.

ADE

Vancouver is running behind.

Malik watches the second hand. It hesitates at twelve. Moves. Hesitates again. He takes the clock down and removes the battery. The ticking stops.

ADE

You won.

MALIK

It is broken.

ADE

That has never stopped you
before.

Malik sets the clock face-down. Three coffees wait beside the sink in a straight line. Ade takes the one at the end. Malik moves the remaining two closer together. Ade notices. He opens the refrigerator. Yellow mustard.

Dijon. Grainy. Ade rests his thumb on the grainy lid. Closes the refrigerator without taking anything.

MALIK

You need to change.

ADE

This is black.

MALIK

Those are sweatpants.

ADE

Grief has lowered its standards.

Malik removes a loose thread from Ade's coat sleeve. Ade lets him. The front door opens again. KAI OKU, 25, enters with a digital camera against his chest and noise-cancelling headphones around his neck.

He stops just inside. Listens. The refrigerator hum. Water moving through old pipes. A delivery truck reversing two houses away. The soft scrape of Malik folding a dish towel into exact thirds.

Kai looks toward the face-down clock.

KAI

What happened to it?

MALIK

It loses time.

Kai turns the clock face-up. The missing battery rests beside it.

KAI

One second every minute.

ADE

Dad bought it at a gas station.

KAI

He hated losing time.

MALIK

Then he should have bought a better clock.

Malik picks up his mug. Still does not drink. Near Solomon's chair sits an old CAMCORDER. Scratched casing. A strip of masking tape underneath: SOLOMON. Kai picks it up.

Presses POWER. Nothing. He opens the battery compartment. Empty.

KAI

Where is the battery?

MALIK

Leave it.

KAI

He kept them in the blue drawer.

Kai crosses to a narrow drawer beside the telephone. Opens it. Rubber bands. Receipts. A tiny screwdriver. Three dead pens. No battery. Kai searches beneath the receipts.

MALIK

Kai.

Kai closes the drawer. Then opens it again.

ADE

Maybe it achieved freedom.

Kai keeps searching.

ADE

The battery. Not Dad.

No one laughs. Ade looks down. Kai removes every object from the drawer and arranges them on the counter. Rubber bands together. Pens parallel. Receipts by size. One receipt is folded around something hard.

Kai opens it. A small BRASS CARVING. Worn smooth at the edges. Animal at one angle. Mask at another. Kai turns it beneath the kitchen light.

MALIK

Put it back.

KAI

What is it?

MALIK

Something he kept.

KAI

That is not an answer.

MALIK

It is this morning.

Kai studies Malik. Sets the carving beside the camcorder. Malik returns it to the receipt. Returns the receipt to the drawer. Closes the drawer firmly. Kai crosses to the crooked photograph.

The three brothers as children beside Solomon. Malik rigid in a suit too large for him. Ade caught halfway through saying something. Kai small enough to be held. Solomon looks directly at the camera. Not smiling.

The frame leans slightly left. Kai straightens it. Steps back. The ceiling light washes Solomon's face from the glass. Kai tilts the frame crooked again. Solomon returns.

KAI

He did that on purpose.

MALIK

Did what?

KAI

Left it wrong.

ADE

Maybe he was testing whether
Malik could feel joy.

Malik lifts three garment bags.

MALIK

Get dressed.

Kai remains by the photographs. On a lower shelf, an empty rectangle interrupts a line of dust. Something stood there long enough to leave an outline.

KAI

What is missing?

Malik checks the folder he brought. Funeral programme.
Death certificate. Three printed schedules.

MALIK

Nothing we need today.

KAI

That is not what I asked.

MALIK

We leave in twelve minutes.

ADE

He made an agenda for Dad's
funeral.

MALIK

Someone had to.

ADE

Yeah.

Too fast. Too sharp. Malik looks at him. Ade softens.

ADE

Imagine the chaos otherwise.
People grieving without assigned
seating.

Malik aligns the folder with the counter's edge.

ADE

There he is.

MALIK

Who?

ADE

Nobody.

Ade takes the garment bags from him. For one brief moment, Malik has nothing in his hands. He looks toward the staircase. The three brothers follow his gaze. The landing is empty. Solomon's bedroom door stands open.

Malik turns away first. On the dining table, the BRASS URN waits beside a vase of white flowers.

Smaller than the silence around it. Malik lifts it. Tests the lid. Once. Again. A faint thumbprint marks the polished brass. He wipes it with his sleeve. The print smears. He wipes harder.

ADE

Malik.

Malik stops. Ade holds out both hands.

ADE

Let me.

Malik looks at the hands. Then at Ade.

MALIK

Take the flowers.

Ade leaves his hands there for another beat. Then takes the vase. Kai switches off the kitchen light. Dawn does the rest. The brothers move toward the door: Ade with flowers and garment bags.

Kai with his camera and the funeral programmes. Malik with their father. Before Kai leaves, he looks back at the crooked photograph. He does not straighten it. The front door closes.

CUT TO:

EXT. MOUNTAIN VIEW CEMETERY - MEMORIAL LAWN - MORNING

Rain hangs in the air without committing to a drop. A white canopy has been raised among cedars. Beneath it: Folding chairs. White flowers. A framed photograph of Solomon. The brass urn at the center. No grave.

A small Nigerian choir sings beside a portable speaker. The sound is beautiful until the speaker dries it into static. Mourners fill the chairs.

Black Canadian wool beside Nigerian formal wear. Old friends from church. Former patients from Solomon's clinic. Neighbours who knew the shape of his car better than the shape of his life.

The brothers stand in the front row. Malik nearest the urn. He has folded the programme into a perfect rectangle. Ade receives condolences with both hands. He gives each person the response they need.

KAI stands half a step behind them. His camera hangs unused. The OFFICIANT reads from the repaired Efik Bible.

OFFICIANT

We return Solomon Oku to the
keeping of those who loved him,
and we ask for mercy upon what
remains unfinished.

Malik's eyes move to the order of service. Final prayer. Hymn. Family departure. He checks that the choir is ready before the officiant has finished speaking. The choir leader raises one hand. The microphone SHRIEKS.

Ordinary feedback. Metallic and sudden. Everyone flinches. Kai folds around the sound. One hand clamps over his right ear. The choir, the rain, the murmuring crowd - all of it collapses into a thin electrical ring.

The officiant's mouth keeps moving. No words reach him. Ade sees. He steps close enough for Kai to feel him.

ADE

Kai.

Kai watches Ade's lips.

ADE

Look at me.

Kai does. Ade breathes slowly. Kai matches him. The speaker is switched off. The ringing recedes. Sound returns in pieces: Shoes shifting on wet grass. Someone coughing into a handkerchief.

The choir continuing without amplification. Malik turns at last.

MALIK

You all right?

KAI

It was loud.

MALIK

I know.

Kai looks at Ade. Ade holds his gaze. At the rear of the canopy, a man waits beside a small travel bag. BODE OKU, 64. Solomon's younger brother.

Rain has darkened the shoulders of his coat. An airline tag still circles the handle of his bag. He arrived too late to hide how far he came. He does not interrupt. He removes his cap for the final prayer.

Malik sees him. Something in Malik's posture hardens before it gives way. The prayer ends. The choir's last note thins beneath the canopy. People rise. Condolences begin moving toward the brothers.

Bode waits until the oldest church women have passed. Then he approaches. He looks at Malik first.

BODE

Malik.

Malik takes his uncle's hand. Bode draws him into a brief, private embrace. He greets Ade. Then Kai.

Kai feels the travel still in Bode's coat: rain, recycled air, a trace of cologne applied in another time zone. Bode looks at the urn. Then back to Malik.

BODE

Was it peaceful?

Malik answers without looking away.

MALIK

Yes.

Ade lowers his eyes. Kai studies Malik. Bode waits. Malik does not revise the answer.

BODE

Good.

A beat.

ADE

You made it.

BODE

Your father spent seventeen years accusing me of being late.

ADE

Was he right?

BODE

Only when somebody else was waiting.

Bode looks at the photograph beside the urn.

BODE

At sixteen, he missed the school bus and ran behind it with his shoes in his hands.

KAI

Why was he not wearing them?

BODE

He said shoes made a man slow.

ADE

Dad said that?

BODE

Your father had many beliefs before he had responsibilities.

Ade laughs. One clean breath of it. Even Malik almost does. The FUNERAL DIRECTOR approaches with respectful distance.

FUNERAL DIRECTOR

Mr. Oku. Whenever your family is ready, you may take the urn.

Malik moves before anyone else can. He gathers the urn against his chest. Ade reaches for the flowers. Bode watches the order settle into place.

FUNERAL DIRECTOR

The reception room is through the south doors.

MALIK

Thank you.

Malik takes one step. His grip tightens. The urn slips less than an inch. His entire body reacts. Bode puts one

hand beneath the base. Malik does not release it. Bode does not pull.

They stand like that while mourners move around them.

MALIK

I have it.

BODE

I know.

Malik's fingers whiten against the brass.

MALIK

I'm trying not to make another mistake for him.

Bode keeps his hand beneath the urn.

BODE

Give me one side.

Malik looks at his uncle's hand. Then shifts his grip enough to make space. Bode takes half the weight. They carry Solomon toward the reception room together. Ade follows with the flowers.

Kai picks up Bode's travel bag.

INT. MOUNTAIN VIEW CEMETERY - RECEPTION ROOM - LATER

Condensation clouds the windows. Coats steam on chair backs. Jollof rice, meat pies, fried plantain, tea. Solomon's brass urn rests where Malik can see it from anywhere in the room.

Mourners contradict one another over the man he was. A woman tells Ade he has Solomon's laugh. Ade thanks her. For the rest of the reception, he smiles without showing his teeth. Malik keeps one hand on the back of the chair nearest the urn.

Kai stops at a photograph on the memorial table. Three young people outside a weathered house: SOLOMON, lean and unsmiling. BODE, younger, one hand raised against the sun. A GIRL between them.

Her face has been scratched away. Not crossed out with ink. Cut from the emulsion with a sharp point, stroke after deliberate stroke. Kai tilts the photograph. The grooves catch the fluorescent light.

Ade steps in beside him. His social smile disappears.

ADE

That was done on purpose.

In the background of the photograph, a brass object rests on the veranda wall. Too small to identify. The same compact silhouette as the carving in Solomon's blue drawer. Bode steps into the edge of their silence.

He sees the photograph. His face settles.

KAI

Who was she?

BODE

Someone your father loved badly.

ADE

Did he do this?

BODE

Not here.

Bode glances at two mourners close enough to hear. Malik joins them.

MALIK

What is it?

Kai gives him the photograph. Malik reads the damage before he reads the people.

BODE

Solomon's lawyer will come to the house tomorrow morning.

MALIK

Why?

BODE

The will.

MALIK

You know what is in it.

BODE

Solomon left instructions. They are for his sons.

Malik looks from the scratched face to the urn.

EXT. MOUNTAIN VIEW CEMETERY - PARKING AREA - AFTERNOON

The rain finally commits. Bode and Malik carry the urn between them beneath one umbrella. The umbrella is too small. Ade walks ahead to open the car.

Kai follows with Bode's travel bag and the scratched photograph protected inside his coat. At the back door, Bode offers to take the urn completely. Malik considers it.

MALIK

One side.

Bode nods. Together, they place Solomon inside.

CUT TO:

INT. SOLOMON'S HOUSE - DINING ROOM - MORNING

The flowers from the funeral have begun to open. The urn stands on the sideboard. The damaged photograph lies face-up on the dining table. Beside it: The brass carving from the blue drawer.

Kai has brought the two objects together. MAYA PATEL, 48, Solomon's estate lawyer, has one slim file and a sealed envelope. Bode sits apart from the brothers.

MAYA

The legal part is simple.

MALIK

That usually means the opposite.

MAYA

Your father left the Oku family house and its adjoining land outside Calabar to the three of you. One undivided gift.

ADE

And if one of us says no?

MAYA

It remains with the family there. You owe nothing. You may refuse.

She places the sealed envelope between them.

MAYA

This is not legally binding. It is for you.

Malik opens it. One sheet in Solomon's tight handwriting. He reads silently. His jaw sets.

ADE

You have to use sound.

Malik gives him the page. Ade reads.

ADE

"My sons. I need you to take me home. All three. Bring my ashes to the river boundary of the Oku land outside Calabar."

No farewell. No signature.

MALIK

He is dead and still assigning seats.

MAYA

You may say no.

MALIK

Did he make the land conditional on it?

MAYA

No. The ashes are a request. The property is a choice the three of you make together. Your uncle agreed to guide you if you go. That is all the will can usefully say.

She closes her file. Malik walks her out.

INT. SOLOMON'S HOUSE - DINING ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Ade holds Solomon's letter. Kai has turned the scratched photograph toward Bode.

KAI

The house in this photograph. Is that it?

BODE

Yes.

Kai places the carving beside the tiny brass shape on the veranda wall. Same broad shoulders. Same narrow center.

KAI

And her?

BODE

Our sister.

KAI

She died there?

BODE

She died. The rest belongs in Calabar.

Malik returns. Takes Solomon's letter from Ade.

MALIK

We are not going.

KAI

You decided quickly.

MALIK

Three people crossing an ocean because a dead man could not speak while he was alive.

ADE

He said what he wanted.

MALIK

He gave us a location.

ADE

For Dad, that was practically intimacy.

Malik does not smile.

KAI

He hid the carving. He kept this picture and destroyed her face. Now he wants all three of us at the house they came from.

MALIK

That is not a pattern. That is an estate.

KAI

It is when everyone refuses the same part of it.

Bode absorbs that.

MALIK

You want to fly across the world
because people are withholding
information?

KAI

I want the silence to stop being
the only thing we inherit.

Malik turns to Bode.

MALIK

Tell him not to go.

BODE

No.

MALIK

You know what is there.

BODE

I know some of what is there.

MALIK

Then decide.

BODE

Solomon asked me to help if you
chose. He did not ask me to
choose for you.

Malik stiffens. Kai looks to Ade. Ade gets up, crosses to
the refrigerator and opens it. Three mustards. He takes
out the grainy one. Stares at it.

ADE

He arranged the room before he
left it.

MALIK

What?

ADE

Dad in the middle. Us around him.
I hate that it worked.

MALIK

Then say no.

ADE

If Kai goes alone, we become the
brothers who let him. If two go
and one stays, we become the ones
who went and the one who did not.

MALIK

That is not a reason to cross an
ocean.

ADE

It is the only reason I trust.

Silence. Ade sits.

ADE

I vote we go together. We carry
him to the river. We ask our
questions. We come home together.

Kai raises one hand.

KAI

Yes.

Malik looks at both of them. They wait for him. Neither
looks away. He unfolds Solomon's letter. Smooths the
crease Ade made.

MALIK

We go together.

Kai waits.

MALIK

We stay together.

ADE

That sounded threatening.

MALIK

It was a condition.

ADE

There he is.

The sound of the room gives way to a SEAT BELT CHIME.

PILOT (V.O.)

Cabin crew, prepare for landing
in Calabar.

CUT TO:

INT. DOMESTIC AIRCRAFT - DESCENDING - AFTERNOON

Green gathers beneath the wing. Water catches the sky
between broad seams of land. The brothers look down at a
place their father spent thirty years refusing to
describe.

The urn remains in its padded case beneath Malik's seat.
His shoes bracket it. Across the aisle, Bode watches the
ground rise to meet them.

WHEELS STRIKE RUNWAY.

EXT. MARGARET EKPO INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT - ARRIVALS - AFTERNOON

The doors open. Heat arrives like a hand laid flat against
the face. Sound follows: Car horns. Names called across
traffic. Trolley wheels hitting broken pavement. An
argument ending in laughter.

The brothers step out carrying Vancouver in the cut of
their clothes. Sweat finds them immediately.

ADE

Canada has been lying about
weather.

The airport keeps everyone close enough to negotiate with.
A PORTER, twenties, moves toward their luggage.

PORTER

Oga, make I help.

He takes hold of Ade's suitcase before anyone answers.
Malik pulls it back.

MALIK

No. Leave it.

The porter keeps one hand on the handle.

PORTER

No worry. I go carry am.

Bode steps beside Malik. He does not raise his voice.

BODE

My brother, leave am. We no need
help.

The porter looks at Bode. Releases the handle.

PORTER

No vex, sir.

Bode nods.

BODE

No problem.

The whole exchange takes five seconds. Malik is still
holding the suitcase too tightly. Bode takes the trolley.

BODE

Come.

The brothers do.

EXT. CALABAR ROAD - BODE'S VEHICLE - LATER

The city passes in layers. Painted shopfronts. Church
signs. School uniforms. Palm shadows sliding across
windshields. Red earth appearing wherever pavement gives
up. Kai films through the window. People.

A mechanic asleep beneath a lifted car. Two girls sharing
earphones. A woman balancing bread on her head while
texting. Bode points through the windscreen toward a road
disappearing into green.

BODE

Your father used to race bicycle
there.

ADE

Dad had a bicycle?

BODE

Your father had a childhood.

KAI

We have not seen evidence.

BODE

He had legs too.

Ade laughs. Malik looks out at the road. For one moment, he tries to place his father on it. Cannot. The city thins. Walls give way to compounds. The air grows greener. Bode turns onto a narrower road.

BODE

Home.

Tires leave asphalt for red earth.

CUT TO:

EXT. OKU FAMILY COMPOUND - LATE AFTERNOON

A broad family compound shaped by additions rather than a single plan. An older central house with deep verandas. A newer concrete wing. Solar panels beside a corrugated roof. Carved doors. Plastic water tanks.

Children's bicycles. Satellite dishes. Laundry moving in the heat. Every part of the compound is in use. The vehicle enters through an open gate. People come out before the engine stops.

COUSIN EYO, 43, practical and quick, opens the rear hatch. Children crowd the brothers until one look from Eyo restores a lane. Then AUNTIE ENO, early sixties, crosses the veranda. She does not hurry.

Everyone else adjusts around her pace. Bode steps forward.

BODE

Mọkọm, Eno.

ENO

Ekọm do.

Eno touches his cheek. Counts the months since she last saw him without asking. Then she turns to the brothers. Malik offers his hand.

ENO

That is all?

MALIK

Good afternoon, Aunty.

ENO

Mọkọm.

MALIK

Mọkọm, Aunty.

ENO

Better.

She ignores the hand and takes his face between both of hers. Turns it toward the light.

ENO

Solomon kept this forehead in Canada.

Malik does not know whether he has been welcomed or examined. Eno releases him. Ade opens his arms.

ADE

I prepared for a hug.

ENO

You people came from Canada and forgot how to greet?

Ade lowers his arms.

ADE

Mokom, Aunty Eno.

He bows his head just enough to make the respect clear without pretending fluency he does not have.

ENO

This one still has mouth.

She pulls him into an embrace. Ade closes his eyes inside it. Only for a second. Eno turns to Kai. He has already removed his camera from between them.

KAI

Mokom, Aunty.

ENO

And this one came to inspect us.

KAI

I am just looking.

ENO

Then greet what you are looking at.

She touches his cheek once. Gentler than the sentence. Then she sees the padded black case in Malik's hand. The compound quiets by degrees. Bode takes off his cap.

BODE

We brought him.

Eno approaches the case. She does not open it. She lays her palm on the lid. The gesture is ordinary. The grief is not.

ENO

You took your time, Solomon.

She removes her hand.

ENO

Bring him inside before the heat insults him. The rest of you - wash. You look like the airport has eaten you.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - FRONT ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

The front room carries several generations without arranging them for visitors. Family portraits. School certificates. A charging station crowded with phones.

An old cabinet of carved wood beneath a flat-screen television. The brass urn is placed on a sturdy side table. Malik checks the surface first. Solid. Level. Eno watches him test it.

ENO

If the table survived this family, it can hold your father.

Malik removes his hand. Children peer through the doorway. Eno turns.

ENO

Give them air.

They disappear. Not far.

Beyond them, at the end of the passage, a narrow door is secured by a faded RED CORD looped between its handle and a brass wall hook. It is the only door in the house that does not stand open.

Kai notices. Eno notices him noticing.

Eyo crosses the passage with folded bedding. The door disappears behind ordinary work.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - DINING ROOM - DUSK

Food reaches the table before questions do. Afang soup. Fufu. Rice. Fried plantain. Grilled fish. Water sweating in glass bottles. The brothers sit among relatives whose names arrive faster than memory can keep them.

Eno serves Malik until he says enough. Then adds one more spoon.

MALIK

Aunty, thank you. That is enough.

ENO

You are negotiating with soup.

ADE

He does it with eggs too.

ENO

Tomorrow I will give him eggs. We will see who wins.

Ade looks at his plate.

ADE

I should warn you, I can cook.

Eno gives him a careful look.

ENO

Confidence is what people use when skill is not available.

The table erupts. Ade accepts the hit. Eyo points his spoon at Bode.

EYO

Tell them about the mangoes.

BODE

There is nothing to tell.

ENO

Because you helped him.

ADE

Dad stole mangoes?

BODE

Borrowed.

ENO

From trees that did not belong to him.

BODE

The trees recovered.

EYO

He sold them back to the owner.

Malik laughs. He looks as startled as anyone. Covers it with water.

ADE

What else could he do?

Eno thinks.

ENO

At twelve he learned how to boil water.

BODE

Eleven.

ENO

Twelve. For one month he entered the kitchen asking why everybody was still working without him.

Ade folds over laughing, one hand braced against the table. He does not check whether anyone follows. Kai smiles. Malik looks toward the urn in the front room.

MALIK

He never told us any of this.

The laughter eases.

ENO

Children do not know their parents were children. Parents work very hard to keep it that way.

KAI

Why?

ENO

Because a child can forgive a father.

She looks toward the front room.

ENO

A child does not always forgive a man.

Bode and Eno share a glance. Small. Old. Kai catches it.

MALIK

What happened here?

ENO

Tonight? You arrived. You ate. Your uncle exaggerated mangoes.

BODE

You accused me first.

ENO

Tomorrow, Bode will show you the land. After that, you can begin asking the land questions as if it owes you answers.

KAI

And you?

ENO

I will still be here when you learn the difference.

She reaches for his plate. Kai protects it.

KAI

I am still eating.

ENO

Good. Canada did not finish you.

The conversation starts again around them. Through the doorway, the urn catches the room light.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - BROTHERS' ROOM - NIGHT

Three narrow beds. Three mosquito nets tied up for air. Suitcases open on the floor. The room is hot enough to make sleep theoretical. Ade lies on one bed, still smiling at the ceiling.

ADE

Mangoes.

MALIK

Go to sleep.

ADE

He sold stolen mangoes back to the man.

KAI

Allegedly.

ADE

No. That is our father. I finally have a complete fact.

Malik removes his watch. Sets it beside the bed.

MALIK

You have a story.

ADE

I will take it.

Kai sits with the scratched photograph. He has placed the brass carving beside it.

MALIK

Put those away.

KAI

The object in the background is the same.

MALIK

We established that.

KAI

No one at dinner mentioned her.

ADE

You did not ask.

KAI

They knew I had already asked.

Malik looks at Bode's younger face in the photograph. Then at the missing one between the brothers.

MALIK

Tomorrow.

Kai looks at him.

MALIK

Not as an answer. As a time.

Kai wraps the photograph again. The brothers settle. Outside: Family voices on the veranda. Cutlery being washed. A generator starting two compounds away.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - BREAKFAST AREA - MORNING

Morning arrives already loud. Eggs. Fried plantain. Bread. Tea. The Afang soup from last night, because Eno does not believe good food must respect the clock.

ENO

Emesiere.

The brothers answer with varying confidence.

BROTHERS

Emesiere nde.

Eno nods. Malik eats the eggs. She watches.

ENO

Well?

MALIK

They are very good.

ENO

Not "very good." Who won?

Malik surrenders one inch.

MALIK

The eggs.

Eno nods. Order restored. Bode enters dressed for the land. Light shirt. Sturdy shoes. A folded map he does not need. Malik notices the map.

BODE

We leave in twenty minutes.

ADE

Now he speaks your language.

BODE

The river path is long. We will show you the boundaries first. If the weather holds, we continue to the water.

Malik looks toward the urn in the front room.

MALIK

Today?

BODE

Today we walk. At the river, you decide if today is the day.

The brothers finish eating.

CUT TO:

EXT. OKU FAMILY COMPOUND - MORNING

Eyo secures water and food in a canvas pack. The brass urn remains inside its padded case. Malik lifts it. Ade reaches for one handle. Malik lets him. Together, they carry Solomon through the gate.

Eno stands on the veranda.

ENO

Bring everybody back before dark.

ADE

No instruction for the dead?

ENO

He has ignored enough instructions.

Bode almost smiles. The four men follow a red-earth path into the family land.

EXT. OKU FAMILY LAND - LATER

The compound disappears behind green. The land is not untouched. It has been worked, abandoned, reclaimed and worked again. Cassava plots. Palm stands. Old drainage cuts softened by rain.

New survey stakes beside boundary stones older than anyone present. Bode stops at the first stone. Three shallow cuts cross its face.

BODE

From here to the river bend. Then
east to the old road.

Malik studies the folded map.

MALIK

The title says forty-two
hectares.

BODE

The title learned the land later.

Malik looks up. Bode points.

BODE

That silk-cotton tree was already
old when your grandfather was
born.

ADE

Does the tree have paperwork?

BODE

Better witnesses.

They continue. Kai photographs the stone. The three cuts
converge around a shallow hollow. He takes the brass
carving from his camera bag and holds it beside the mark.
The angles differ. Both hollows sit slightly off-center.

KAI

Uncle Bode.

Bode looks from one mark to the other.

BODE

It marks Oku land.

KAI

And the carving?

BODE

It came from here.

KAI

Was it hers?

Bode looks at the carving.

BODE

Put it away.

Kai wraps the carving and returns it to his bag. They
walk.

EXT. OLD PALM TRACK - LATER

The path narrows beneath a layered canopy. Heat becomes
wet pressure. The urn passes from Malik and Ade to Malik
and Bode. Then to Ade alone for a short rise. Each
transfer is careful. No ceremony. Practice.

Bode points to a tree bent low across the path.

BODE

Solomon planted that after our mother said nothing useful would grow where he put it.

ADE

Spite farming.

BODE

Your father's most reliable crop.

The tree is enormous now. Malik touches its trunk as he passes. Farther on, the path divides around a washout. Bode stops the group.

BODE

From here, stay on the path I take.

ADE

You say that like we have been freelancing.

BODE

Sound travels badly here. Water bends it. Trees throw it back. If you hear one of us, look for us before you follow.

Kai studies the two paths.

BODE

And do not believe everything you think you see. Distance changes quickly under these trees.

Bode takes the left fork. The others follow.

EXT. BOUNDARY PATH - LATER

The boundary stones return at no regular distance. Each one stands on the right side of the path.

A fallen limb has peeled vines from the slope to Kai's left. Beneath them: An older stone carrying the same three cuts. Facing downhill.

Kai raises his camera. Ahead, Malik and Ade negotiate the urn over a fallen trunk. Bode watches their footing.

Kai steps off the path to frame the exposed stone.

EXT. SLOPE ABOVE THE RAVINE - CONTINUOUS

He takes two careful steps. Wet leaves shear away beneath his shoe. The slope gives. Kai slides, camera clutched to his chest. His free hand catches a root. The root tears loose.

Kai drops into the ravine.

EXT. HIDDEN SHRINE - CONTINUOUS

He lands hard enough to empty his lungs. For several seconds: Mud. Breath. Pain. Kai checks the camera. Unbroken. One scraped palm.

The exposed boundary stone is not freestanding. It is the upper corner of a SHRINE.

Stone and tree have grown into one body. The masonry rises from the ravine wall, soft at the edges from age. Roots enter through old seams and emerge as carved lines. Some roots protect it.

Others appear to hold it shut. At its center: A narrow recess covered by a small slab of wood. The wood is bound to the stone with faded RED THREAD.

Pale grooves circle the wood at different heights beneath the thread. Earlier bindings. Kai remains where he fell. He looks up the slope. The family is no longer visible. Movement somewhere above. No words he can make out.

Kai takes the carving from his camera bag. The roots describe the same three cuts around a hollow. He holds the carving beside them. Photographs both.

Kai approaches. He touches the wood. Dry beneath the damp air. The red thread crosses itself in a practiced knot. One loop can be loosened without cutting.

Kai works a fingertip beneath the loop. The thread resists. He stops. Looks back toward the slope. Pulls again.

The old thread snaps -- a dry little sound. The forest continues around him. Insects. Birds. Leaves rubbing in the upper air. Kai catches the wooden cover before it falls.

Behind it, a recess blackened by age. Inside: A BRASS TALISMAN. Palm-sized. Green at the edges. Its design holds the same three converging lines. Here, the hollow at their center is filled.

Kai studies where it sits. Photographs it. Then removes it with two fingers.

The moment the brass clears the recess --

Insects. Birds. The upper leaves.

Gone.

The talisman pulls heat from Kai's fingers.

Another PALM beneath his. Older. Red thread cutting across both hands.

River water at his chest.

Somewhere below --

BRASS STRIKES STONE.

Kai drops to one knee. His jaw locks against a cry. The talisman remains in his fist. The empty recess waits at eye level.

His free hand moves toward it. Stops.

The ground answers with one DEEP BEAT. Impact through root and stone. Kai feels it in his teeth. High above, leaves turn their pale undersides toward the ravine.

MALIK (O.S.)

Kai!

Kai raises the talisman toward the recess. Holds it one inch from where it sat.

MALIK (O.S.)

Kai!

Kai closes his hand. Slips the talisman into his camera bag.

At the base of the shrine, something moves. A BLACK SPIDER emerges from the seam between root and stone. Small. Unhurried. It crosses the snapped red thread.

Stops on the broken loop.

BODE (O.S.)

Kai!

Bode's voice cracks on the name. Kai looks toward the slope. Then back at the shrine. The spider begins to follow the broken thread toward open ground.

CUT TO BLACK.

FADE IN:

EXT. OKU FAMILY LAND - RIVER BOUNDARY - LATE AFTERNOON

The river moves beneath a low amber sky.

Broad. Brown. Unhurried.

Leaves and reflected light travel the current. The forest crowds both banks, older than everyone standing before it.

Bode removes his sandals and leaves them beside the exposed roots of a tree. He steps into the water until it reaches his ankles. Bends. Touches two fingers to the current.

Waits.

Then looks back at the brothers.

BODE

Face the current.

Malik removes his shoes. Ade follows.

Kai is last. Mud dries across one knee. His camera bag hangs high against his chest. Malik looks at Kai's closed, scraped hand. Kai enters the water.

Bode returns to the bank and steps back from the water.

The BRASS URN rests in Malik's hands.

Smaller now than the journey built around it.

Malik opens it. Looks down at the ash. His fingers tighten around the rim.

Ade steps beside him. Places one hand on Malik's shoulder.
Malik looks to Kai.
Kai nods.
Malik tips the urn.
The first ash touches the river and spreads in pale veils.
Some sinks immediately. Some catches the current.
No music.
Water against their legs. Leaves shifting above them.
Insects working invisibly in the heat.
Malik tips the urn farther. Ade lowers his head. Kai
follows each grey strand until the river takes it.
A last dusting gathers along the lip.
Malik taps the base once.
One narrow ribbon of ash settles on the current.
The water moves beneath it.
The ash holds.
Kai sees it.
Then the ribbon opens. Separates. Disappears.
The river continues.
A bird calls beyond the trees.
Malik lowers the empty urn. Kneels. Rinses the ash from
his fingertips.
The grey leaves his skin.
When he stands, his shoulders sit lower.
Ade looks downstream. Opens his mouth. Closes it.
Kai shuts his eyes.
The brothers remain in the current. Wind moves over the
water. Sunlight breaks across it.
Then one insect stops.
A thin metallic chirr from the left bank cuts off
mid-pulse.
Another disappears farther in.
Then another.
The change travels through the forest.
Life withdrawing from sound.
Ade opens his eyes.
The breeze weakens. Leaves settle. The surface of the
river smooths around their legs.
A bird lands above the bank.
Does not call.

Malik's hand rises to the back of his neck.
He looks over his shoulder.
Only water. Only forest.
His body locks.
One second.
Air returns to him. He lowers his hand.
Ade turns toward the bank. The beginning of a smile finds his face.
No joke follows.
Kai remains facing downstream. His gaze fixes beyond the bend.
The trees seem closer.
He blinks.
They are where they were.
Malik stops breathing.
Ade's unfinished smile disappears.
Kai's shoulders draw tight.
All at once.
Nothing touches them.
None of them turns.
The moment passes.
Wind crosses the river. Insects restart unevenly. The bird leaves the branch. Water breaks around their ankles.
Malik steps first. Ade follows. Kai waits a beat before moving.
They leave the river separately, though they entered it together.
Bode watches from the bank.
Malik rubs the back of his neck and reaches for his collar.
Ade says nothing.
Kai keeps his eyes from the trees.
Bode looks past them toward the river.
Nothing there.
He picks up Malik's shoes and hands them over.

BODE

Let's go.

The brothers dress. Bode starts up the path faster than he walked down.
Still short of a run.

After several steps --

BODE

Don't look back.

No one does.

Behind them, the current passes over the place where the ash held together.

Nothing holds there now.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - BROTHERS' ROOM - NIGHT

The mosquito nets are down.

Three pale rooms inside one dark room.

The ceiling fan turns above them. Its bearings complain once each revolution. Family voices thin across the compound. A basin empties. A bolt slides home. Someone laughs on the veranda and is answered from farther away.

The house settles around its living.

Malik lies on his back, eyes open. The empty brass urn rests inside its padded case near his bed.

Ade faces the wall. One foot outside his net.

Kai lies nearest the door. His camera bag is on the floor beneath him. One hand hangs over the edge of the mattress, inches from it.

ADE

Everybody sleeping?

MALIK

Until now.

ADE

Good. I did not want to be alone
in this heat.

No one gives him the laugh.

ADE

That was not the frightening
part.

The fan turns.

Outside, the last conversation stops mid-sentence.

The insects stop with it.

Not fading. Gone.

All three brothers look toward the window.

The fan keeps turning.

Malik's mattress lowers beside him.

The springs give one small complaint.

Ade lifts his head.

Kai's hand closes around the edge of his bed.

A DEEP BEAT lands inside his chest.
The mosquito net beside Malik's face draws inward.
A breath touches the skin below his ear.

MALIK

Who is there?

No answer.

Ade looks through two layers of netting. Malik is alone.
Kai is watching from the other bed.

From the hollow Malik's body has not made --

ADE.

Ade sits up.

ADE

I heard you.

MALIK

I did not speak.

The mattress sinks another inch.

The beat strikes Kai again.

This time Ade hears the bed springs answer it.

Kai presses both hands to his sternum. His pulse chases something slower.

KAI

Do you feel that?

MALIK

Feel what?

From beneath Kai's bed, in Malik's voice --

Don't answer.

Malik hears it too.

All three are still.

Then, close to Ade --

Say something.

Ade's mouth opens on instinct.

He closes it.

The turning fan throws a slow cross of shadow across the wall.

Kai sits up.

His shadow remains lying down.

One revolution.

It sits up after him.

Kai stares at it.

KAI

Who said that?

ADE

Which part?

The room door frames the passage beyond.

It holds a darker shade of night.

A voice arrives inside Kai's breathing.

You can still close it.

He grips the bed frame.

The next beat lands.

Kai is on his feet before it finishes.

MALIK

Kai.

Kai looks at Malik.

Or tries to.

His eyes keep returning to the passage.

He lifts the camera bag from the floor and holds it against his chest.

ADE

Where are you going?

Kai does not answer.

He steps through the doorway.

Ade is out of bed behind him.

Malik reaches beside his mattress. His hand closes around the handle of the empty urn case.

He follows.

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - PASSAGE - CONTINUOUS

Kai moves barefoot through the dark.

Moonlight reaches the passage through patterned ventilation blocks. It cuts the floor into pale shapes that do not join.

Family photographs hold brief pieces of faces.

At the far end: the RED-CORDED DOOR.

Kai's shadow follows a fraction late.

At the next block of moonlight, it passes him.

Kai stops.

The shadow continues along the wall. Reaches the red-corded door first.

His arm begins to rise.

He seizes his own wrist.

Behind him, Ade enters the passage.

Kai does not seem to see him.

The deep beat has found a rhythm now.

With each impact, the distance to the door becomes uncertain. Ten feet. Six. Ten again.

From behind the door, Kai hears Ade laugh once.

No breath in it.

Then Malik calls his name from somewhere wet and far below the floor.

The actual Malik enters behind Ade, carrying the empty urn case.

MALIK

Kai.

The voice behind the door says it with him.

Kai's shadow raises its hand to the red cord.

Kai's fingers open.

ADE

Kai.

Kai turns toward the nearer voice.

His body keeps moving toward the other.

He reaches.

A hand closes around his wrist.

He twists hard, almost striking --

Ade.

Real. Barefoot. Breathing.

ADE

It is me.

Kai stares at him.

KAI

Which one?

Ade has no joke for that.

ADE

The one holding you.

The rhythm in Kai's chest breaks.

The passage returns by pieces. Wall. Photographs.

Moonlight. A closed door with an old cord around it.

MALIK

Was one of you in my bed?

Ade looks at him.

ADE

No.

MALIK

Someone was breathing.

Kai looks toward the red door.

KAI

Something was talking.

A floorboard shifts inside the brothers' room. All three turn.

No one stands there.

Ade keeps hold of Kai's wrist.

ADE

We are done pretending
separately.

Malik looks from Kai's camera bag to the red cord.

MALIK

Where is Bode?

CUT TO:

INT. OKU FAMILY HOUSE - KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER

One burner holds a kettle below a full boil.

Bode sits alone at the kitchen table. A folded dishcloth beside his hand.

The brothers enter together.

Bode sees Ade holding Kai's wrist. Malik carrying the urn case. Kai carrying the camera bag.

He switches off the burner.

BODE

What happened?

MALIK

Why is that door tied shut?

Bode looks toward the passage.

BODE

What happened?

ADE

Voices.

Malik turns to him.

ADE

From both beds. Neither of you
was speaking.

MALIK

Something lay down beside me.

They look at Kai.

Kai keeps his eyes on Bode.

KAI

It said I could close what I
opened.

Bode's hand closes around the edge of the table.

BODE

What did you open?

KAI

I don't know.

MALIK

He found another boundary stone.
He stepped off to photograph it.
He fell.

BODE

That is what he told you.

KAI

That is what happened.

BODE

It is not all that happened.

The EMPTY BRASS URN sounds inside its case.
One clear metallic note. No one has touched it.
Malik sets the case on the table. Opens it.
The urn is still. From inside Kai's camera bag --
A smaller, duller answer.
Bode stands.

BODE

Put the bag down.

Kai does not move.

MALIK

Kai.

ADE

No more pieces.

Kai sets the bag on the table.
Bode does not open it. He circles once, looking.
A faded strand of RED THREAD is caught beneath the bag's
lower flap. Mud has dried into its fibers. One snapped
loop remains intact.
Bode draws it free. The thread lies across his fingers
like rubbish.
He turns the surviving loop inward. Passes one broken end
beneath it. Draws the other across.
The debris resolves into workmanship: three crossings
around an absent center.
Bode's hands stop.

BODE

Where is what this held?

Kai looks at the bag.

Malik reaches for it.

Kai catches his wrist.

For a second, the brothers hold each other across the table.

Kai releases him. Opens the bag himself.

Removes the BRASS TALISMAN. Sets it between the broken knot and Solomon's empty urn.

Bode's knees find the chair behind him.

ADE

You know it.

Bode looks at Kai.

BODE

Did you remove this?

KAI

Yes.

BODE

Did you put it back?

Kai cannot make the answer smaller.

KAI

No.

Malik turns away. Both hands on the counter.

MALIK

You stole it.

KAI

I was trying to understand it.

MALIK

You always say that after.

ADE

Malik.

MALIK

After he opens it. After he takes it. After it is breathing in my bed.

Kai looks at the empty place inside the urn case.

Bode lifts the broken knot.

BODE

You knew it was closed.

KAI

I knew somebody had closed it. I did not know why.

BODE

So you decided the reason belonged to you.

KAI

No. I decided the question did.

Ade moves between their sightlines before the room can divide.

ADE

It used our voices.

Bode looks at him.

ADE

Or something close enough.

BODE

What did it say?

ADE

My name. Told me to say something.

MALIK

It said nothing to me.

BODE

It did not need to.

Malik goes still.

KAI

It told me I could close it.

Bode folds the clean cloth over the talisman without touching the brass.

BODE

It is not speaking to you.

He wraps the object once. No knot.

BODE

It is learning what you answer to.

Nobody speaks.

MALIK

What is it?

Bode looks toward the dark passage. Toward the door bound in red.

BODE

I know what we called it. I do not know if what we called it was true.

ENO (O.S.)

Why are all of you awake?

Eno stands in the kitchen doorway. Wrapper secured over her nightclothes. Fully awake.

She sees four men waiting for someone else to speak.

Then Bode's hands around a piece of broken red thread.

His thumb keeps working the snapped end.

ENO

What happened?

Bode looks at Kai.

BODE

He left the path.

ENO

Where?

BODE

Below the western stones.

Eno looks at Bode. He cannot hold her gaze.

ENO

Eyo will sleep near the children.
These boys stay here.

BODE

Eno --

ENO

You can explain after everybody
is safe.

KAI

Can we put it back?

BODE

Not the way you took it.

Bode places one hand over the cloth.

BODE

No one touches this.

Outside, one dog begins barking toward the family land. A
second answers from farther away. Then a third.

Eno reaches for the kettle. Refills it. Relights the
burner.

ENO

Sit down.

CUT TO BLACK.